

NO PANIC, ONLY PREPARATION

▶ **After handling three Covid-19 waves since March 2020, India Inc. is confident of tackling another surge in infections**

▶ **Firms have now institutionalised a number of decisions for crisis situations—such as which roles can go remote, which roles have to be in-office, what circulars have to be sent out to employees, etc.**

▶ **About 70 per cent of Indians are fully vaccinated, but only 27 per cent have taken booster shots. A high level of vaccinations among employees is also giving India Inc. confidence**

▶ **Organisations are not pressing the panic button on official travel yet. Besides, work-related travel is already minimal because of the holiday season**

▶ **Tech investments into AI, cloud, data analytics, etc., are also coming to their aid for a seamless transition to WFH if required. For example, chatbots are deployed to answer questions about mediclaim, insurance policies, and so on.**

as Cloud, AI, automation and data analytics as part of their digital transformation journeys, have also prepared them to deal better with any employee concerns and disruptions. “Our focus has been to ensure that employees have instant access to information—such as mediclaim policy and insurance guidelines—that was much needed during Covid-19. So, our chatbot platform came to the forefront,” says Jayakumar. “Many HR heads are seeing demos of new-age HCM [human capital management] platforms. The main focus is on keeping productivity intact while working remotely,” says Sumit Sabharwal, CEO of TeamLease HRtech, the HCM vertical of TeamLease Services.

Even in industries where working remotely is not possible—such as manufacturing, logistics and healthcare—firms are using HCM solutions to ensure business continuity. “For instance, Oracle HCM Solutions is assisting healthcare providers like Apollo Hospitals Enterprises, Sir Ganga Ram Hospital, Omega Healthcare and many more in streamlining their workforce across business-working models,” says Shaakun Khanna, Vice President, HCM & SaaS Application Alliances, APAC at Oracle.

India’s high vaccination rate is inspiring confidence and rooting out scepticism among enterprises in dealing with any future waves of the Covid-19 virus. About 70 per cent of Indians are fully vaccinated, but only 27 per cent have taken the booster shot. The recent cases have been dominated by the Omicron sub variant BF.7, which studies show has a high transmission rate. Mumbai-based conglomerate RPG Enterprises has not reinstated any pandemic-era restrictions yet. “Our vaccinated numbers are quite high. We already have a post-pandemic, perpetual RPG Remote Working Policy in place that provides [employees] flexibility to be on WFH based on their work classification.

Depending on their job, we allow up to 50 per cent WFH flexibility,” says S. Venkatesh, President (Group HR) of the RPG Group.

Countries including China, Japan, South Korea, the US and Brazil are witnessing a spike in Covid-19 cases. The Indian government has made it mandatory for travellers from some of these countries to fill out the Air Suvidha Self Declaration forms before arriving. But official travel plans, domestic or international, have not been impacted so far, the experts say. “We are not creating unnecessary panic by telling employees

INVESTMENTS THAT ENTER- PRISES HAVE BEEN MAKING INTO TECH HAVE PREPARED THEM TO DEAL BETTER WITH EMPLOYEE CONCERNS AND DISRUPTIONS

not to travel. We will follow whatever requisite guidelines the authorities give out,” says Raymond’s Mane. Besides, the holiday season means that work-related travel is anyway at a minimum, points out Roopank Chaudhary, Partner & Chief Commercial Officer, HCM (India and South Asia) at Aon, a financial services firm. The only disconnect could be if employers feel there is no risk for employees to come into work but employees feel otherwise, he adds. “The alignment between employers and employees is key, but from the perspectives of processes, learnings and implementation, there should be no challenge.” **BT**

@SaysVidya